

THE

CLIMB MAP

A Leadership Self-Assessment

Identify the terrain you're on. Find your next move.

4,500+	#1	Top 4%
Classroom Hours	USAF PME Instructor 3 Years Running	Master Instructor Certification (CIC 3)

Jeff Carley | Master Instructor (CIC 3) | jeffcarleyleadership.com

Adapted from curriculum taught at Airman Leadership School, Ellsworth AFB

HOW TO USE THIS WORKSHEET

The Climb Map is a four-terrain leadership self-assessment adapted from material developed and refined across 4,500+ hours of classroom instruction at Airman Leadership School, Ellsworth AFB.

- 1** **Set aside 15 uninterrupted minutes.** This isn't a quiz — it's a diagnostic. Give it the space it deserves.
- 2** **Work through all four terrains.** Score each of the five questions per terrain honestly. 1 = almost never true. 5 = consistently true.
- 3** **Be honest, not aspirational.** Score where you actually are, not where you're trying to get. The assessment only works if you tell the truth.
- 4** **Add up your scores.** Transfer your five scores from each terrain to the scoring page at the end. Your total guides your terrain identification.
- 5** **Read your terrain — then do the action.** Knowing your terrain is the start. The micro-action at the end of each terrain section is where the climb begins.

A NOTE ON HONESTY

Most leaders score themselves 1-2 points higher than their teams would score them. If you're unsure whether a statement is "usually true" or "consistently true," ask someone you lead. Their answer is the more accurate one. The gap between how you see yourself and how your team experiences you is the most important data in this worksheet.

TERRAIN ONE

The Foothills — Early Leadership

You have the role. The tools haven't caught up yet.

You were promoted because of what you did — not because of what you knew about leading people. The skills that got you here are real, but they're individual skills. Leadership is a team sport. Welcome to the gap.

QUESTIONS — SCORE EACH 1 TO 5

1 = Almost never
true

2 = Rarely true

3 = Sometimes
true

4 = Usually true

5 = Consistently
true

1

Am I spending more time doing the work myself instead of directing others to do it?

2

Do I explain my decisions, or just deliver them?

3

Do I know what motivates each person I lead — not the group, but each person?

4

When something goes wrong, is my first instinct to fix it or to develop the person who missed it?

5

Am I building trust or just building compliance?

TERRAIN 1 TOTAL SCORE

Add your 5 scores above

____ / 25

WHY THIS TERRAIN MATTERS

The Foothills are where most new leaders stall permanently. Not because they lack intelligence — because they mistake activity for leadership. The faster you stop doing and start developing, the faster you climb.

THIS WEEK'S ACTION

This week: pick one task you currently own that someone on your team could own. Transfer it completely. Don't check in for 48 hours.

WATCH FOR THIS

Watch for this: if you find yourself doing something "because it's faster," you're in the Foothills.

TERRAIN TWO

The Ridge — Developing Leader

You know what good looks like. Doing it under pressure is the problem.

You have enough experience to know when you're leading well and when you're not. The gap isn't knowledge — it's consistency. Pressure reveals the version of yourself you haven't fully replaced yet.

QUESTIONS — SCORE EACH 1 TO 5

1 = Almost never
true

2 = Rarely true

3 = Sometimes
true

4 = Usually true

5 = Consistently
true

1 When I'm under pressure, do I lead the same way as when things are calm? _____

2 Do the people I lead feel psychologically safe enough to tell me bad news? _____

3 Can I name the specific development area I'm working on right now? _____

4 Do I give feedback in the moment or let it accumulate until it's heavy? _____

5 Am I building leaders below me, or just good followers? _____

TERRAIN 2 TOTAL SCORE

Add your 5 scores above

____ / 25

WHY THIS TERRAIN MATTERS

The Ridge is where good leaders plateau. They lead well most of the time — but "most of the time" isn't a culture. Culture is what happens when you're tired, frustrated, and behind. That version of you is setting the real standard.

THIS WEEK'S ACTION

This week: think of one feedback conversation you've been rescheduling. Have it this week. Scheduled discomfort is better than accumulated silence.

WATCH FOR THIS

Watch for this: if people on your team seem surprised when you lose your composure, you're on the Ridge. They see it — you just haven't built the gap between trigger and response yet.

TERRAIN THREE

High Altitude — Advanced Leader

You lead well. Your ceiling is now culture, not competence.

At this altitude, your individual performance isn't the constraint anymore. The question is whether the environment you've built can sustain excellence without you in the room. Nobody's telling you what you don't know — because nobody feels safe enough, or because nobody knows either.

QUESTIONS — SCORE EACH 1 TO 5

1 = Almost never
true

2 = Rarely true

3 = Sometimes
true

4 = Usually true

5 = Consistently
true

- 1 Does my team perform the same whether I'm present or not? _____
- 2 Do I actively seek out what I'm wrong about? _____
- 3 Can I name the specific ways my leadership style costs people something? _____
- 4 Am I developing leaders, or developing good performers? _____
- 5 Is the culture of my team something they would describe the same way I would? _____

TERRAIN 3 TOTAL SCORE

Add your 5 scores above

_____ / 25

WHY THIS TERRAIN MATTERS

High Altitude leaders often stop getting honest feedback — not because they've earned immunity, but because people stop offering it. If you're not actively creating the conditions for honesty, you're flying without instruments.

THIS WEEK'S ACTION

This week: ask someone you lead directly — "What's one thing about the way I lead that makes your job harder?" Then listen. Do not defend. Do not explain. Only ask clarifying questions.

WATCH FOR THIS

Watch for this: if you haven't heard something that surprised or stung you in the last 90 days, your feedback systems are broken. High performers adapt to what leaders reward — not what leaders say they want.

TERRAIN FOUR

Above Treeline — Senior Leader

You're leading leaders. The metrics are slow and indirect.

Above treeline, the environment is stripped of everything familiar. No vegetation to shelter behind. Every decision is exposed. The work now isn't execution — it's transmission. You're not building results. You're building the people who build results, and the culture that makes results sustainable.

QUESTIONS — SCORE EACH 1 TO 5

1 = Almost never
true

2 = Rarely true

3 = Sometimes
true

4 = Usually true

5 = Consistently
true

- 1 Do the leaders below me lead in a way consistent with our values — not just our directives? _____
- 2 Am I building leaders who can replace me and lead better than I did? _____
- 3 Is my organization capable of telling me the truth about itself? _____
- 4 Do I understand the second and third-order effects of my decisions on people two levels below me? _____
- 5 Am I protecting the mission and the people — or just managing risk for myself? _____

TERRAIN 4 TOTAL SCORE

Add your 5 scores above

_____ / 25

WHY THIS TERRAIN MATTERS

Above treeline, the most dangerous failure is invisible: leaders who perform well in front of you and break people below you. Your job at this altitude is to build systems that make that impossible — and to eliminate the incentive structures that make it rational.

THIS WEEK'S ACTION

This week: talk to someone two levels below your direct reports. Not about performance. About what it's like. What they see. What they wish was different. Listen for the gap between what you think is happening and what is.

WATCH FOR THIS

Watch for this: if the people below you are always calm and always agreeable, you've built a culture of performance, not truth. Truth is uncomfortable. If leadership at your level is always comfortable, something is being hidden.

TRANSFER YOUR SCORES

TERRAIN	NAME	YOUR SCORE	/25
1	The Foothills	_____	25
2	The Ridge	_____	25
3	High Altitude	_____	25
4	Above Treeline	_____	25
TOTAL		_____	100

WHAT YOUR SCORE MEANS

20–35**Terrain One — The Foothills**

Your instincts are pointing you toward doing and delivering. That's where your energy goes. The work now is learning to multiply through people instead of replacing them. Start with Question 1's action from the Foothills terrain.

36–55**Terrain Two — The Ridge**

You have the knowledge. You're learning how to deploy it under pressure. The gap between your best days and your hardest days is narrowing — but it's still there. One consistent practice, done daily, closes this gap faster than anything else.

56–75**Terrain Three — High Altitude**

You lead well most of the time. Your edge now is the culture you're building — what happens when you're not there, when things get hard, when the stakes go up. The question to keep asking: are people being honest with me?

76–100**Terrain Four — Above Treeline**

The work at this altitude is legacy, transmission, and truth. You're building people who build people. Your greatest risk isn't failure — it's isolation. Stay close to the people doing the actual work. Listen more than you speak.

COMMITMENT SECTION

Knowing your terrain is information. What you do with it is leadership.

My current terrain is:

The one thing I'm avoiding that I need to address:

One action I commit to this week:

I will do this by (date):

One person I'll share this with (accountability):

WHAT TO DO NEXT



Book a Free Discovery Session

30 minutes with Jeff. No pitch — just clarity on your terrain and your next move.
jeffcarleyleadership.com/#coaching



Join the Weekly Leadership Notes

One actionable insight every week. Story-driven, practical, built for the climb.
jeffcarleyleadership.com/#newsletter



Take the 5 Questions Assessment

The free companion self-assessment. No email required. 5 minutes. jeffcarleyleadership.com/5-questions

“Leadership is a craft, not a personality. It can be taught. Start here.”

— Jeff Carley